

Non-Stop Inertia

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Precarity 2.0

The rootless worker cannot be uprooted. In an environment where jobs (or “assignments”) appear and disappear at such a rate as to seem unreal, mundane everyday worries – home insecurity, debt, bureaucracy – are regularly amplified into supernatural threats by those who co-ordinate this environment. The dread which lies behind such taken-for-granted stress cannot be clearly defined but nevertheless seems to be a constant background presence. Daily life becomes precarious. Planning ahead becomes difficult, routines are impossible to establish. Work, of whatever sort, might begin or end anywhere at a moment’s notice, and the burden is always on the worker to create the next opportunity and to surf between roles. The individual must exist in a state of constant readiness. Predictable income, savings, the fixed category of “occupation”: all belong to another historical world.

It seems vital, then, to give a name and a shape to this amorphous fear which presents itself to the post-Fordised subject as a force of nature or as something emanating from inside the individual rather than a deliberate external arrangement of power; and some theorists of contemporary work, including the philosopher Paolo Virno, have indeed named this particular constellation of insecurities as “Precarity”:

It is a fear in which two previously separate things become merged: on one hand, fear of concrete dangers, for example, losing one's job. On the other hand, a much more general fear, an anguish, which lacks a precise object, and this is the feeling of precarity itself. It is the relationship with the world as a whole as a source of danger. These two things normally were separated. Fear for a determinate reason was something socially governable while anguish over precarity, over finitude, was something that religions or philosophy tried to administer. Now, by contrast, with globalisation these two elements become one.⁹

Feelings of sudden existential vulnerability now come upon the individual as if from nowhere, in the midst of indifference, in the banal space of work; at the customer service counter, in a warehouse or call centre, as s/he services the remote needs of the globalised professional class in an almost colonial fashion. And this fear also follows the unanchored worker out of the nominal workplace and into the home: it fills gaps in conversations, is readable between the lines of emails, seeps into relationships and crevices of the mind. The precarious worker is then saddled with an additional duty: to *hide* these feelings.

Precarity is a term which has gained currency in the last decade through its use by various anti-globalisation and anti-capitalist protest networks, sometimes involving the appropriation of its religious associations (the word originates in Catholic terminology).¹⁰ However the idea among some activists that post-Fordist capitalism must eventually topple under the weight of its own insecurities and liberate the so-called "precariat" seems less hopeful today, in the wake of a financial crisis which has resulted not in

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Jobseeking as Career

So the welfare state is giving way to privatised training courses and “work for the dole” schemes, while the job of jobseeking yields ever more precarious and intermittent work. From the responsibilities of the Jobcentre customer to the self-marketing duties of the unpaid intern, from the agency worker on permanent standby to the Virtual Assistant in search of virtual clients, the distinction between employment and unemployment seems increasingly arbitrary. While their formal differences are maintained by a border-patrolling bureaucracy, in terms of (lack of) content they are approaching a point of convergence. The new privatised version of unemployment has its own job description, person specification and disciplinary framework, so that if you do not perform your jobseeking duties correctly you can be fired by your line manager. Meanwhile for many employees the old-fashioned purposeful social activity of work has been replaced by a similarly privatised and professionalised form of jobseeking-on-the-job, a vocation which is attended to not only in the act of “looking busy” and selling oneself to the boss during work hours, but also by scrolling through vacancies and filling in applications during downtime and the parenthetical hours of commuting. Jobseeking has become something abstract, an entire worldview such as used to be provided by the structure of work itself. And under the conditions of precarity and short-term

insecurity, this work never ends.

The situation is illustrated by opening at random any one of the relentless torrent of CV-building self-help manuals: “The world of work is changing fast... . We are all applying for jobs more frequently in an increasingly competitive environment. Job-search skills that we used to need only at the start of a long period with one employer now need to be regularly sharpened and practised.”⁶³ Jobseeking is an exercise regime which we are told we should all maintain, as we never know when we might have to run for our lives. The constant reorganisations of roles and workplaces, as described earlier, obviously contribute to this anxious treadmill of virtual mobility. But there is no discussion of exactly *why* this should be the case; the ultra-focused jobseeker has no time or energy for such airy-fairy concerns, and raising the issue in an appraisal or interview would be like questioning the existence of God during Holy Communion.

A key feature of this jobseeking-as-career orientation is the business of CV-grooming. I used to imagine CVs or résumés as being limited to professional performers and executives, but now apparently they are a matter for everyone, from factory workers and checkout assistants to students and the long-term unemployed. The CV is a particular sub-genre of post-Fordist autobiography, a copy-and-paste cosmetic narrative which accentuates the positives and papers over any cracks; ironically, at a time when continuity in work is at its weakest, one’s life history must be made to seem as smooth and characterless as a shampoo advertisement. This again is a form of emotional labour, a micro-management of feeling. Can I force myself into a state of enthusiasm as I string together various unwanted and unfulfilling jobs and

inflate their personal significance, while reducing my identity to a series of bullet points? If I can, then once again, this is a triumph of style over substance. And the personal project of the CV is ongoing, never finished: as the Job Club members in Sharone's study are reminded, "writing résumés is ... a continuous process of editing and revising".⁶⁴ These endlessly editable documents are virtual projections of ourselves as frictionless vehicles, constantly adapting and moving forward. They bear no relation to the gridlocked reality which they try so desperately to repress: even if superficially tailored (or Taylorized?) to a specific vacancy, the result is bound to be both "personalised" and utterly anonymous.

Just as the CV is a sort of all-purpose packaging of the self, recruiters use the same sort of jargon to interpellate the jobseeker, either directly or remotely, in ways which are both absolutely generic and individually targeted, like a director throwing out a standard line to an out-of-work actor and saying, "OK, show me what you can do with this". For instance, the Reed job agency sends out regular mass emails which hail the recipient by name, incorporating her/him into relentlessly upbeat subject headers: "Ivor, make your first days as a temp stand out", "Ivor, add some variety to your working life", "Ivor, what's your next career move?" and my personal favourite: "Britain's got talent. What's yours, Ivor?"

Recruitment agencies are like the private welfare-to-work providers but without the social pretence; in their take-it-or-leave-it approach, the agencies have an open disregard for the reserve labourer which the welfare providers must keep hidden. The individual is compelled, by lack of other options, to offer himself for the agency's consideration, but the agency has no compulsion to reciprocate. Consequently, where the Jobcentre demands a performance of surface acting in which the unemployee is required to go

through the motions, dealing with the agency is a matter of deep acting, of not merely following the script but nuancing and personalising it. As shown by their publicity materials which feature an ever-changing cast of up-for-anything guys and flexible IT girls, agencies promise utter detachment from the *content* of work, which appears to exist in a social vacuum, and at the same time demand absolute positive engagement with its *form*, its language of individual aspiration and presentation.

The jobseeker who successfully “plays” the agencies becomes, in Virno’s terms, a virtuoso, selecting the most suitable elements from that generic communicative repertoire which resonates across the contemporary globalised work-space. The old skills of craftsmanship or technical proficiency are now secondary, even in manual occupations, to the new skill of linguistic and semiotic virtuosity, a kind of *stagecraft*: being able to adapt to whatever environment and identity one is thrown into and improvise a role around its unwritten rules of costume, gesture and language. A sort of verbal dexterity, the “gift of the gab”, which in the Fordist era would have been associated with sales work or with working one’s way deliberately up the career ladder, is now generalised and compulsory in interviews and trial periods and then in the job itself. If the old Fordist factory worker is seen as having a minor role in a long-running serial, then the post-Fordist agency actor skips from one advertisement to the next, following the circular narrative of the digital network rather than the old linearity of the production line.

The endless unpaid duties assigned to the virtuoso jobseeker cast him as the postmodernised inversion of the 1980s “gizza job” persona, which confronted the employer directly with the physical reality of the reserve labourer and his family. Now, rather than proclaiming his jobless status the career jobseeker

hides it, like something obscene, behind a screen of training courses and voluntary work and expressions of rictus positivity, and he becomes ever more complicit with this concealment in proportion to his desperation. The jobseeker must have an alibi ready to explain away every gap in his employment history, while the most mundane experience becomes the occasion of a personal epiphany: “working in a busy café really taught me something about the importance of customer service.” Skills are valued over knowledge. Non-vocational qualifications are almost a liability, unless they are emptied of content; a degree in literature is valued not for its evidence of critical thought but because it shows that the applicant has word processing experience.

What are we not thinking about during all those hours of jobseeking, networking and CV-building? What interests, worries and fantasies might we otherwise have? What books might we read (other than self-help manuals), what conversations might we have with colleagues and friends about topics other than work? How differently might we perceive our current jobs without this constant needling insecurity? What kind of dangerous spaces might open up, in what kind of jeopardy might we put ourselves and this dynamic system, if we resigned from our jobs as jobseekers?

Ways Out

In Herman Melville's short story "Bartleby, The Scrivener" (1853), negation is taken to its ultimate conclusion in the employee's single, repeated phrase: "I would prefer not to."⁶⁹ The story, narrated from the point of view of a somewhat complacent employer who believes that "the easiest way of life is the best", hinges on the relation between Bartleby and his boss, and specifically the boss's growing involuntary – indeed from his own point of view absurd – sense of responsibility for this recalcitrant scribe, an attachment which is obscurely deepened not only by his non-worker's negative preferences but by his refusal to explain them. By withholding himself, as well as his labour, Bartleby gains a certain power over the boss: he takes up residence in his conscience as well as his office.

It is unsurprising, then, that Bartleby is much admired by revolutionary philosophers and resentful workers. For most present-day employees, however, such outright refusal is not possible, not just for practical reasons (which are clearly of no interest to Bartleby himself) but because of the slippery, ungraspable dimensions of the 21st century workplace. Which is to say, if Bartleby had been an agency worker the fiction would have turned out rather differently. If one fancifully imagines a temporary data enterer who preferred not to perform the tasks assigned to him, this would present today's office man-

ager with no such terrible insight. The boss, again following the path of least resistance, would simply shrug and acknowledge this as the worker's choice, without even questioning his reasons, and order a new temp from the agency to take his place. This new Bartleby could conceivably even keep returning to the non-workplace throughout various reorganisations and changes of ownership to be gently ridiculed by successive employers, like a piece of novelty furniture. He would still perish, of course, in some indeterminate non-place, but no-one would witness his final act of rebellion other than perhaps another temporary worker, say a cleaner or security guard. There would be no-one to turn away from, except himself and his own kind. The levels of mediation and the transience which are built into temp work, as well as the informality of the flexible team, mean that direct confrontation between worker and employer is bypassed. The question then is how to short-circuit this flow of indifference, how to articulate negation in a culture from which negativity itself has been banished.

A sort of low-level or latent precarity, as experienced by myself and many others, is now a fixture of everyday life, both taken-for-granted and uncanny, immanent and untraceable; a vague electrical hum, hardly worth mentioning, too trivial to be worth complaining about (“it’ll only be for a while”, “at least I have a job”, “it’s the same for everyone”, “that’s just the way things are”). Especially with the guillotine poised over public services today, this repressed anxiety is fast becoming the norm; jobs dissolve into *Apprentice-style* compete-or-die self-marketing exercises, with the social purpose of the institution practically forgotten.